

Travel for tech!

If you're still undecided about your holiday destination, check out an interesting list of getaways on page 52

Cover feature

smartphone, using a technique known as tethering. Plus, you get access to Apple's vast storehouse of secure and tested apps. Also, when you are in public places such as airports, access to wireless internet is generally provided for free. Moreover, you are reducing the sheer amount of hardware you would have otherwise have stuffed in your luggage.

Must haves

Whether it's your first trip to your planned destination, or whether you frequent this place every year, there are some things that will never change. You'll always need information such as exchange rates, taxi charges, best places to dine and also the best times to visit.

Exchange rates

Go to xe.com/mobile, and select the app for your version. XE covers more currency conversions than you'll ever need.

Local attractions

Once you've reached your destination, you're pretty much at the mercy of the people around you to guide you and inform you of the best shopping areas around, or even the major attractions of the place. Go to lonelyplanet.com/mobile and download the app for Android, iOS or mobile depending on your platform and you can have all the information you'll ever need. This is better than carrying a thick and heavy book around. Wouldn't you prefer carrying more shopping bags instead?

Genuine feedback

The best thing about user feedback is that you can be more sure that it's unbiased than some of the travel sites, since many hotels tie up with popular travel services to get good reviews, and to be the top suggestion. At tripadvisor.com/mobile you can get an app and receive advice from real people who will tell you whether hotel or homestay arrangements are worth it or not – and for destinations all over the globe.

Offline maps

Navigation is a great technology. GPS, A-GPS, triangulation are terms that

sound good. But they render you helpless if they don't work. The best option is to have maps on your phone that don't need a data connection to update. Thankfully, there is an option to download offline maps at offmaps.com and mapsdroyd.com.

You can also go to offlinemaps.codeplex.com and download Google Maps offline. With Google Maps offline, you no longer need a data connection or network coverage, or GPS signals, for that matter to find your way. Of course a GPS-enabled phone or a dedicated GPS device might be the best bet if you're travelling cross country across deserts or something. Google Maps will not get you to water!

Local weather forecast

Have you ever planned a family vacation by the beach, only to have all your plans thwarted by a storm? Before you begin your trip, make sure you know what to expect in terms of the weather conditions. From your smartphone, go to mobile.yahoo.com/weather and follow the instructions given on the page, specific to your mobile platform to stay updated with weather forecasts.

Cheap international calling

Mobile phone companies are extremely eager and happy to help you when you enquire about international roaming. They ought to be. If you consider the rates of international roaming with your service provider, you'll know why. A call from the US to India, while on roaming will cost you ₹165 per minute! Go to tinyurl.com/skp-mob and get the Skype app for your platform. If your phone doesn't support Skype, you can also buy Matrix calling cards that offer cheap call rates globally. For more details, go to matrix.in. They're not cheap, but they are cheaper than ₹165 a minute!

Precious moments

It's the interesting pictures that we share with our friends and relatives and comments we hear that add joy to our trips. You can add detail to your pictures with nifty functions such as geotagging available on networks such as Flickr. Go to mobile.yahoo.com/flickr and download the app for your platform. 



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